



Win for the ages: Devine's fortune in World Cups was filled with heartbreak. New Zealand was knocked out in the group stages in all editions across two formats until the 2024 edition. ^{AP}

both awards — brought out her guitar. After a few vocal warm-ups, the White Ferns group took a few steps back to address their captain, Sophie Devine.

Amelia's sister Jess led the vocals as the group sang *'Te Iwi E'*, a Māori song that expresses pride for one's ancestors who made sacrifices for their land.

"*Rū ana te whenua whatiwhati. Hei!* (The ground shakes and quivers, yeah!)" Devine joined in, before an emotional 'thank you' left her lips, the NZ captain visibly humbled and a little embarrassed all at once.

The players and staff then queued up to give Devine a long, tight hug. Also present were family members of the White Ferns, with former New Zealand cricketer and Maddy Green's partner Liz Perry and broadcaster and Bates' partner Scotty Stevenson at the forefront of the celebrations. After the high-octane and public coronation as world champion, the group needed that private moment to pinch itself out of the shock of the occasion and realise that it had indeed conquered the world.

Cricket may not be war, but Devine

— alongside others of the old guard, Tahuhu and Bates — have been through the wringer in their own journeys in this game.

Devine is an eloquent speaker, a trait we've unfortunately seen more in New Zealand or her franchise's defeats. She is happy to bare the wounds of the game, honestly dissect fault lines, and exude positivity for the players under her care and the fans pinning their hopes on them.

On Sunday, for a change, Devine was lost for words when called upon by Mel Jones to make sense of the triumph.

"Once I get my hands on that trophy, it will sink in," she said. "I started to dream last night about what it feels like to hold the trophy with this team. I didn't want to get ahead of us. It's been a long time for this group, for Suzie and Lea, for New Zealand cricket. The great thing about this group is we know what we have been trying to achieve in the last 15, 18, 24 months. We kept taking steps in the right direction."

Losing 10 games in a row to rivals like England (home and away this season) and Australia is not the best

confidence booster in a World Cup year.

The batting order was not clicking, and questions were asked of Devine as to why, during a tournament as important as this, she wasn't pushing herself up the order to give New Zealand a better start. There was an added veil of pressure after she revealed that this would be her last tournament as the captain of the White Ferns.

"You want momentum, and we came to the World Cup on the back of 10 successive losses. But everyone starts on zero," she said early on in the tournament.

Glass ceiling

Devine's tenure as skipper of this group began full-time in 2020, when the world was plunged into the uncertainty of the pandemic. Her predecessor and Tahuhu's partner, Amy Satterthwaite, had taken time off to have her first child, leaving Devine in charge. It was a transitioning team for the Kiwis, with several familiar faces making way for a new generation of talents.

Devine's fortune in World Cups